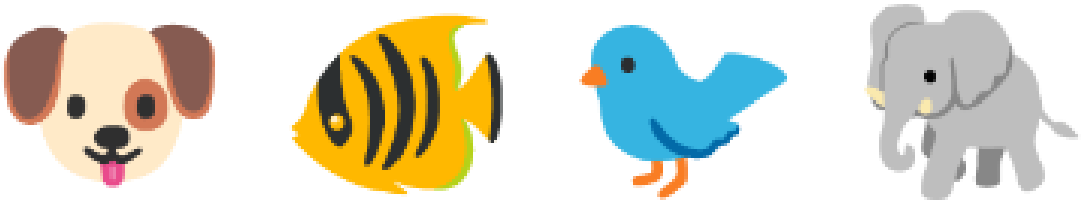
Little Lab Coats

🐾 What Do ALL Animals Need? 🐾

Life Science — Animal Needs | Unit 3, Lesson 1 of 6

📚 **Grade:** Kindergarten ⏱️ **Duration:** 30–45 minutes 🔬 **Subject:** Life Science — Animal Needs 🌿 **Unit:** Unit 3, Lesson 1 of 6



From tiny fish to giant elephants — all animals share four basic needs to survive!

📋 **NGSS Standard:**
K-LS1-1 — Use observations to describe patterns of what plants and animals (including humans) need to survive.

🎯 Learning Objective

Students will **NAME and DESCRIBE** the four basic needs (food, water, air, and shelter) that all animals share, and give one example of each.

💡 The Big Idea

Every animal on Earth — from the tiniest ant to the biggest blue whale — needs four things to **survive**. These needs are the same no matter where an animal lives or what it looks like:

🍎 **Food**

💧 **Water**

🌬️ **Air**

🏠 **Shelter**

💡 **Key vocabulary:** survive, needs, food, water, air, shelter

📦 Materials

🏠 Gather These Household Items

- Bowl of water
- Small snack (crackers or raisins)
- A hand fan or piece of cardboard (to fan yourself and feel air — air is all around us, not stored in a container!)
- Small box or container (represents shelter)
- Stuffed animals or family pet
- Paper and crayons

🎲 Distractor Items for the Sort

- Toy car, crayon, coin, book, or any other household objects that are *not* survival needs

🔬 Let's Get Started

Step 1 — Introduce the Big Question (5 min)
Hold up a stuffed animal (or point to the family pet). Ask: *"What does this animal need to stay alive? What would happen if it didn't have food for a week? What about water?"*

Let kids brainstorm freely. Write or draw their ideas on paper. Then reveal: *"Scientists have figured out that ALL animals need exactly four things to survive. Let's find out what they are!"*

Step 2 — Meet the Four Needs (5–8 min)
Gather your four items and introduce them one at a time:

- 🍎 **Food** — Hold up the snack. *"Animals need food for energy. Without energy, they can't move, grow, or do anything!"*
- 💧 **Water** — Hold up the bowl. *"Every animal needs water. Even animals that live in deserts find ways to get water!"*
- 🌬️ **Air** — Fan yourself or breathe gently on your hand. Ask: *"Can you feel that? What is it?"* → Air! *"Air is all around us — you can't hold it in a box, but you can feel it. Animals need air — specifically a gas called oxygen — to breathe."*
- 🏠 **Shelter** — Hold up the small box. *"Shelter is a safe place to rest, stay warm, and hide from danger. It could be a den, a nest, a pond, or even a dog bed!"*

🌬️ **Air is everywhere!** Fan yourself with a piece of paper or a hand fan and ask "What do you feel?" (air / wind). Breathe gently on your child's hand — *"That's air! It's all around us — animals breathe it wherever they are, not from a container."* Great sensory hook for little learners.

Step 3 — Survival Sorting! (10–12 min)
Spread out all your items on the floor: the four survival items (snack, water bowl, hand fan/cardboard, box) AND the distractor items (toy car, crayon, coin, etc.).

Call out items one at a time and ask: *"Does a dog need this to survive?"*

- Bowl of water → ✅ YES — survival need (Water)
- Crackers → ✅ YES — survival need (Food)
- Fan/cardboard (wave it to feel air) → ✅ YES — survival need (Air — air is everywhere, we just used the fan to FEEL it!)
- Box → ✅ YES — survival need (Shelter)
- Toy car → ❌ Nope — fun, but not needed to survive!
- Crayon → ❌ Nope — same!
- Coin → ❌ Nope — animals don't use money 😄

Make two piles: **NEEDS** and **NOT NEEDS**.

Step 4 — Needs Hunt! (8–10 min)
Go on a "Needs Hunt" around the house! Look for evidence of where your pet (or stuffed animal) gets each need met:

- 🍎 **Food** — Where is the pet food bowl or food kept?
- 💧 **Water** — Where is the water bowl?
- 🌬️ **Air** — Open a window! Air is everywhere — animals breathe it wherever they are.
- 🏠 **Shelter** — Where does the pet sleep? Their bed, a tank, a cage?

If no pet: use a stuffed animal! *"Where would we put this animal's food bowl? Where would it sleep?"* Set it all up in a little pretend habitat corner.

Step 5 — Wrap-Up (3–5 min)
Point to each item on the floor and have kids shout out the four needs in order: *"FOOD! WATER! AIR! SHELTER!"*
Ask: *"Can you remember all four? Let's see if you can say them without looking!"*

💬 Discussion Question

🐠 vs 🐕 — Think about this together:

"Do you think a fish needs the same things as a dog?"

Give kids a moment to think and share their ideas before offering the answer below.

💡 **Suggested Answer:** Yes! Both a fish and a dog need food, water, air, and shelter — but they get those things in *different ways*.

A fish uses **gills** to pull the oxygen out of water — the same oxygen we breathe from air, just dissolved in water instead. A dog breathes air directly with **lungs** and might sleep in a cozy dog bed. Same four needs — very different methods!

Follow-up: "Can you think of another animal? What does IT need?"

🚀 Extensions

- 🎨 **Habitat Diorama:** Build a mini habitat for a stuffed animal in a shoebox. Include all four needs: a tiny food bowl, a water cup, a toy "shelter," and air (it's already there — just name it!).
- 📚 **Read Aloud:** *"What Do Animals Need?"* by Lisa J. Amstutz or *"Living Things and Their Needs"* by Daniel Nunn.
- 🌿 **Nature Walk:** Go outside and try to spot evidence of animal needs in the wild — a bird's nest (shelter!), a puddle (water!), berries on a bush (food!)
- 🔢 **Animal Matching Game:** Name an animal, name one of its four needs, and describe how it meets that specific need. Take turns!
- 📖 **Unit Preview:** *"Next time, we're going to look at just ONE need up close — stay tuned!"* (Builds anticipation for Lesson 2.)

👩‍🏫 Parent/Teacher Notes

- **No materials to buy** — everything needed is already in your home!
- **Introducing "air":** Fan your child's hand or breathe gently on it — ask "what do you feel?" Air is everywhere, not stored in a container. The key concept is that air is all around us; we don't need to capture it in something to show it exists.
- **No pet?** Use a stuffed animal as a stand-in. Set up a little "habitat corner" for it with a pretend food bowl, water cup, and bed.
- **Introduce vocab:** survive, needs, food, water, air, shelter. Keep coming back to these words throughout the lesson.
- **This is the foundation lesson** — all five other lessons in this unit build on these four needs. Getting kids fluent in "food, water, air, shelter" sets them up for everything that follows.
- **Don't worry about perfect sorting** — the discussion matters more than accuracy. If a child says "a toy car" is a need, ask them why! It's a window into their thinking.

🐾 My Animal Needs Worksheet 🐾

Life Science — Animal Needs | Unit 3, Lesson 1 of 6

Name: _____ Date: _____

In each box, draw one way your pet (or favorite animal) gets that need met!

🍎

Food

Draw how your animal gets its food!

💧

Water

Draw how your animal gets its water!

🌬️

Air

Draw how your animal breathes!

🏠

Shelter

Draw where your animal sleeps or hides!

🌍 **Bonus:** Can you name ALL FOUR needs without looking at the boxes above?

_____ _____ _____ _____

✂️ Survival Sorting Mat ✂️

Name: _____ Date: _____

Cut out the item cards below. Sort each one: does an animal NEED it to survive, or is it just extra?

✅ SURVIVAL NEED Animals need this to live!	❌ NOT A NEED Nice to have, but not required
Glue or place your NEED cards here	Glue or place your NOT A NEED cards here

✂️ Item Cards — Cut These Out!

Cut along the dashed lines and sort onto the mat above.

🍎 **Apples (food)**	💧 **Bowl of water**	🌬️ **Air (feel it — wave your hand!)**	🏠 **A cozy den (shelter)**
🚗 **Toy car**	🖍️ **Crayon**	🪙 **Coin**	🌿 **Grass (food for some!)**
🪺 **Bird's nest (shelter)**	📱 **Phone**	🐟 **Fish food (flakes)**	🎁 **Gift box**

📄 **View Reference Card (Full Poster)**

✅ PARENT ANSWER KEY — Detach before giving worksheet to students

✅ SURVIVAL NEEDS

🍎 Apples — *Food*

💧 Bowl of water — *Water*

🌬️ Air — *Air (oxygen) — it's all around us, we can feel it!*

🏠 A cozy den — *Shelter*

🌿 Grass — *Food (for herbivores like rabbits, horses, cows)*

🪺 Bird's nest — *Shelter*

🐟 Fish food (flakes) — *Food (what you feed a pet fish — a clear survival need!)*

❌ NOT SURVIVAL NEEDS

🚗 Toy car — fun for us, not for animals!

🖍️ Crayon — creative, but not survival

🪙 Coin — animals don't use money 😄

📱 Phone — no service in the wild!

🎁 Gift box — nice surprise, but not needed

💡 Discussion Hint Notes

- 🌿 **Grass card:** Kids might say grass isn't food — great teaching moment! It IS food for many animals (herbivores). Encourage kids to think about who eats what.
- 🪺 **Bird's nest:** Reinforce "shelter" — shelter doesn't have to be a house. It's any safe place to rest and stay protected. Nests, burrows, caves, and dens all count!
- 🌬️ **Air card:** Air is everywhere — reinforce that animals don't get air "from a container." Fan your hand or breathe on it: *"That's air! It's all around us — animals breathe it wherever they are."*
- **Fish and water:** Fish also need oxygen to survive — but instead of breathing air like we do, their gills extract dissolved oxygen directly from water. This connects to the Discussion Question about fish vs. dogs.

✅ What Success Looks Like

- Child can name all four needs: food, water, air, shelter (with prompting is fine at this stage!)
- Child can correctly sort at least 3 of the 4 survival need cards into the NEEDS column.
- Child can say one thing about how their pet (or favorite animal) gets at least ONE need met.
- Child can answer the discussion question: *"Yes, a fish and a dog need the same things — just differently!"*

📚 Unit Preview (For Your Planning)

This is **Lesson 1 of 6** in Unit 3: Animal Needs. Every lesson builds on these four needs:

- Lesson 2 — Food: What do different animals eat?
- Lesson 3 — Breathing: How do different animals breathe?
- Lesson 4 — How Animals Drink: How do animals find and use water?
- Lesson 5 — Building a Shelter: What makes a good home?
- Lesson 6 — When Needs Aren't Met: Putting it all together

🧠✅

Ready to test what you learned?

See how much you know about Animal Needs with the unit quiz!

→ Take the Unit Quiz

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🍽️ What's for Dinner? How Animals Eat 🍽️

Life Science — Animal Needs | Unit 3, Lesson 2 of 6

📚 **Grade:** Kindergarten ⏱️ **Duration:** 30–45 minutes 🌿 **Subject:** Life Science — Animal Needs 🔬 **NGSS:** K-LS1-1

Some animals eat plants. Some eat meat. Some eat both — just like us!

📋 **NGSS Standard:**
K-LS1-1 — Use observations to describe patterns of what plants and animals (including humans) need to survive.

🎯 Learning Objective

Students will **SORT at least 6 animals** into herbivore, carnivore, or omnivore categories and **EXPLAIN their reasoning** for at least one choice.

💡 Key Concept

Animals eat different things to survi e eat both. Scientists have special names for each group. Knowing what an animal eats helps us understand how it lives — and how all animals in nature depend on each other.

Herbivore Eats plants only
Leaves, grass, fruit, seed

Carnivore Eats meat only

Omnivore Eats both
Plants AND meat

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💡 **Key vocabulary:** herbivore, carnivore, omnivore, food, survive, sort, plants, meat

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🫁 Breathing: Lungs, Gills, and More 🐟

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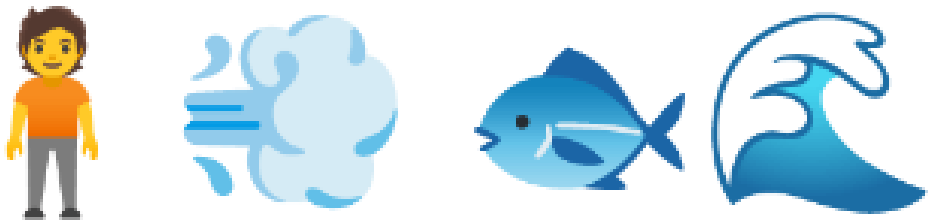
📚 **Grade:** Kindergarten ⏱️ **Duration:** 30–45 minutes 🔬 **Subject:** Life Science — Animal Needs



All animals need oxygen to survive — but not all animals breathe the same way!

📋 **NGSS Standard: K-LS1-1** — Use observations to describe patterns of what plants and animals (including humans) need to survive.

🎯 Learning Objective

Students will **IDENTIFY** that all animals need oxygen and **DESCRIBE** the difference between lungs and gills with at least one example of each.

🔬 The Big Idea

Every animal alive needs **oxygen** — it's one of the most important things on the Animal Survival Checklist! But here's the cool part: animals get oxygen in different ways depending on where they live.

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💧 Water, Water Everywhere: How Animals Drink 💧

Life Science — Animal Needs | Unit 3, Lesson 4 of 6

📚 **Grade:** Kindergarten ⏱️ **Duration:** 30–45 minutes 🔬 **Subject:** Life Science — Animal Needs

Every animal needs water — but they don't all get it the same way!

📋 **NGSS Standard:**
K-LS1-1 — Use observations to describe patterns of what plants and animals (including humans) need to survive.

🎯 Learning Objective

Students will **DESCRIBE at least 3 different ways animals get water** and **MATCH** each method to a specific animal example.

💡 The Big Idea

All animals need water to survive — it's one of their four basic needs (remember from Lesson 1!). But not every animal sips from a puddle. Animals have amazing and surprising ways to get the water they need. Dogs lap, frogs soak, and desert tortoises munch on juicy cactus. Today, you'll discover all three methods — and try them yourself!

🔤 **Key Vocabulary:** absorb, moisture, hydration, desert adaptati

absorb | moisture | hydration | adaptation | lap | permeable

absorb = to soak up | *moisture* = tiny amounts of water | *hydration* = getting enough water | *adaptation* = a cool trick for surviving in tough places | *lap* = to scoop water with the tongue | *permeable* = lets water pass through

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🏠 Building a Shelter: Every Animal Needs a Home 🏠

Life Science — Animal Needs | Unit 3, Lesson 5 of 6

📚 **Grade:** Kindergarten ⏱️ **Duration:** 30–45 minutes 🔬 **Subject:** Life Science — Animal Needs 📋 **Unit 3, Lesson 5 of 6**

Birds weave nests, rabbits dig burrows, bears find dens — every animal builds or finds a home!

📋 **NGSS Standard:**
K-LS1-1 — Use observations to describe patterns of what plants and animals (including humans) need to survive.

🎯 Learning Objective

Students will **BUILD a model shelter** for a toy animal using household materials, **IDENTIFY** at least 2 things a shelter must protect an animal from, and **EXPLAIN** why their shelter design meets those needs.

💡 The Big Idea

Every animal needs shelter to survive. A shelter protects an animal from weather (cold, wind), **hides them from predators** (animals that might eat them), and gives them a cozy place to **rest and raise their babies**. Without shelter, animals would be cold, wet, and in danger.

> 🔑 **Key Vocabulary:** shelter, predator, protection, [illegible]

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🌿 When Needs Aren't Met: What Happens? 🌿

Life Science — Animal Needs | Unit 3, Lesson 6 of 6

📚 **Grade:** Kindergarten ⏱️ **Duration:** 30–45 minutes 🔬 **Subject:** Life Science — Animal Needs 📋 **Unit:** Unit 3, Lesson 6 of 6

Birds migrate, bears hibernate, squirrels adapt — every animal has a plan for survival!

📋 **NGSS Standard:**
K-LS1-1 — Use observations to describe patterns of what plants and animals (including humans) need to survive.

🎯 Learning Objective

Students will **PREDICT and EXPLAIN** what happens when an animal can't get one of its basic needs, and **NAME** at least 2 of the 3 survival strategies (migrate, hibernate, adapt) with a real animal example for each.

💡 **Key Vocabulary:**

migrate **hibernate** **adapt** **survive** **predator** **prey** **food chain**

🔬 The Big Idea

We've learned that every animal needs **food, water, air, and shelter** to survive. But what happens when one of those needs suddenly disappears? Animals can't just wait. They have to adapt. There are three main survival strategies:

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Migrate

Move to a new place where needs CAN be met. Birds fly south in winter to find food and warmth.

Hibernate (or Torpor)

Go into a deep sleep and use stored energy to survive until conditions improve. Bears actually enter *torpor* — a lighter sleep. Ground squirrels and bats do true hibernation!

Adapt

Change behavior or grow special features — like squirrels storing nuts, or animals growing thicker fur.

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